

Communication

Character **First**

SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION: EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Tod et al. (2011), review of communication training in sports teams: positive and information-rich communication shows improvements in cohesion and performance.

RCT Holt et al. (2020), randomized intervention with NVC in youth teams: teams trained in NVC for 8 weeks showed significantly higher social cohesion and fewer conflicts vs. control group. *Psychology of Sport & Exercise*.

Observational study Turnnidge & Côté (2018), direct observation of coach communication: positive and information-rich communication correlates with higher sport enjoyment, motivation, and persistence in young athletes.

GUIDANCE FEEDBACK TRIO ROUND

- 1 Divide the team into groups of three. Role A: giver, Role B: receiver, Role C: observer. The giver gives feedback to the receiver about something concrete (behavior in training, attitude, cooperation). The observer only watches tone and word choice, not content.
- 2 After each round (3 minutes) the observer gives 30 seconds feedback: "You said... That sounded like..." No judgment. Only observation. Then switch roles.
- 3 Close with: "What was hardest about giving? What was hardest about receiving?" Use the answers to lead the group conversation.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Introduce the I-Message in your own coaching language. Stop with "You did that wrong." Start with "I see you leaving the position. I need you to wait for the signal." Players adopt this model when they hear it from you.

Tip 2: Make the difficult conversation concretely actionable: ask players to plan a date and follow up the following week. Accountability is essential, otherwise it stays at intentions.

Tip 3: Players from U14 to U16 are still developing empathic capacity. Be patient. The goal is awareness, not perfection. One deliberate I-message per month is already a success.

⚠ Be careful: the feedback round can become intense if there is underlying tension in the team. Scan group dynamics before starting. In a tense atmosphere: start with positive feedback (strengths) before switching to growth points.

TIMING

- ☐ Explanation of I-Message model: 8 minutes
- ☐ Individual practice with worksheet: 8 minutes
- ☐ Feedback Trio Round: 15 minutes
- ☐ Debrief and reflection: 7 minutes
- ☐ Planning difficult conversation intention: 2 minutes